

Klobuchar, Marshall Urge DOJ and FTC to Investigate Consolidation of Firefighter Software

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U.S. Senators Amy Klobuchar (D-MN) and Roger Marshall (R-KS) are urging U.S. Assistant Attorney General for Antitrust Gail Slater and Federal Trade Commission Chair Andrew Ferguson to investigate consolidation of critical services and products used by fire and public safety departments nationwide.

Recent reports indicate a single company backed by private equity has acquired multiple fire service software businesses and now controls software used by approximately 20,000 of the nation's 30,000 fire departments.

Following consolidation, some fire departments reported steep price increases, from \$795 per year to more than \$5,000 annually. The company has also removed cost-effective options previously available to small and volunteer fire departments, forcing them toward pricier software solutions.

The senators wrote that these companies appear to be taking advantage of the reality that communities depend on specialized products essential to first responders' work: "Smaller emergency agencies ... should not be forced to purchase more expensive products that they neither need nor want simply because consolidation has reduced choice and competition."

The letter also noted broader market consolidation affecting fire departments across fire engine manufacturing, emergency radios, and fire retardants, with companies able to increase prices without losing business due to limited alternatives.

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